seawater and was never quite the same again.[61] Twice the expedition set off, only to be obliged to return after the Amirs of Sindh refused permission for the boats to travel any further.

The necessary permissions were finally received on 4 March 1831, after Ranjit Singh was induced to make various unpleasant threats to the Amirs. From this point the expedition made slow progress upstream for the 700 miles to Lahore. Burnes ducked potshots from the banks, while making detailed jottings on the landscape, peoples and politics of the country they were drifting past. Meanwhile his companions discreetly took soundings and bearings, measuring the flow of the river and preparing detailed maps and flow charts. The Indus proved unexpectedly shallow and Ellenborough's ideas of introducing steamers on the Ganges model was quickly shown to be implausible. But the expedition proved that the River Indus was navigable as far as Lahore in flat-bottomed boats. Barges would be able to take British manufactures as far as the Sikh capital, where they could be unloaded on the banks of the Ravi, and hence carried over the passes to Afghanistan and Central Asia on foot. The only obstacles were political.

Alexander Burnes, the man chosen to lead this mission, was a tough, high-spirited and resourceful young Highland Scot, the fourth son of the Provost of Montrose. He had a broad face, high forehead, deeply inset eyes and a quizzical set to his mouth which hinted at both his curious and enquiring nature and his sense of humour, something he shared with his cousin, the Scottish national poet Robbie Burns.[62]

At the Montrose Academy where he and his brothers had been educated, Burnes was remembered as the 'foremost in bold adventures' rather than for any scholarly achievements, though his classical education there kindled his obsession with Alexander the Great which first drew him to Afghanistan and the Indus.[63]

Shipped off to India with his elder brother James at the age of sixteen, he had now, at the age of only twenty-six, spent a decade in India and grown to be a confident speaker of Persian and Hindustani; he had also perfected a clear and lively prose style, and developed his earlier historical interests: his first publication – 'On the Indus', in the *Transactions of the Bombay*